

The Incas

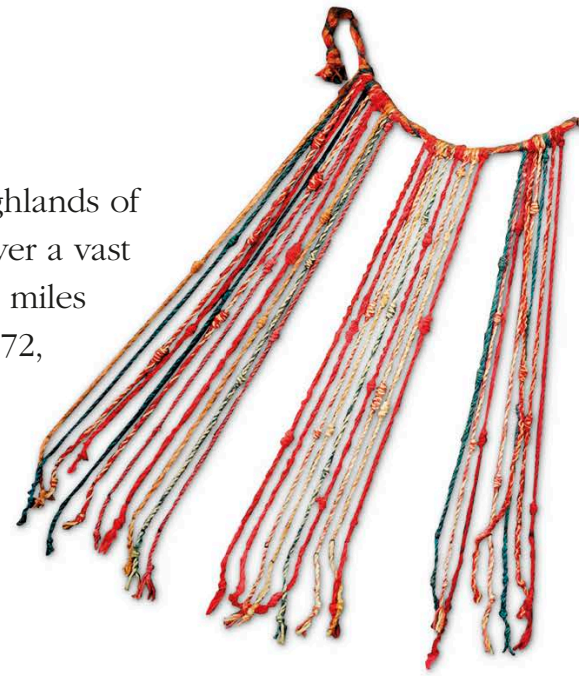
In the 12th century, the Incas established their kingdom in the highlands of modern-day Peru. The Inca Empire grew from around 1430 to cover a vast portion of the Andes mountains. At its peak, it extended for 2,200 miles (3,500km), and included 12 million people. Between 1532 and 1572, the Inca Empire was gradually conquered by Spanish invaders.

Rich civilizations existed in Peru long before the Incas, including the Chimú Empire, who made beautiful pottery and metalwork. They were conquered by the Incas in the 1460s.

The Inca Empire was ruled by an emperor, who was called the *Sapa Ina* (sole lord). Beneath him, society was highly organized with thousands of officials and, under them, millions of common people, who were weavers, farmers, and builders. The Incas built great structures out of enormous blocks of stone that were so well

made, they could withstand earthquakes. They built flat terraces for farming on mountainsides, and dug water channels to irrigate them. Llamas were used to carry soil up from the valley to fill the terraces.

The Incas also built a network of stone roads around 24,000 miles (40,000 km) in length. As well as transporting armies and goods, they were used by official messengers called *chasquis* (fast runners who traveled in relay). Many of these roads are still in use today.



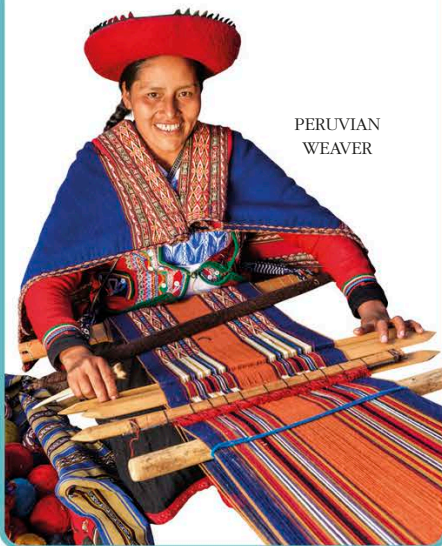
KEEPING RECORDS ▲

The Incas had no written language, but kept records on a device made of lengths of knotted string called a quipu.

The colors of the string, and the position, size, and number of knots provided details such as livestock figures and tax payments.

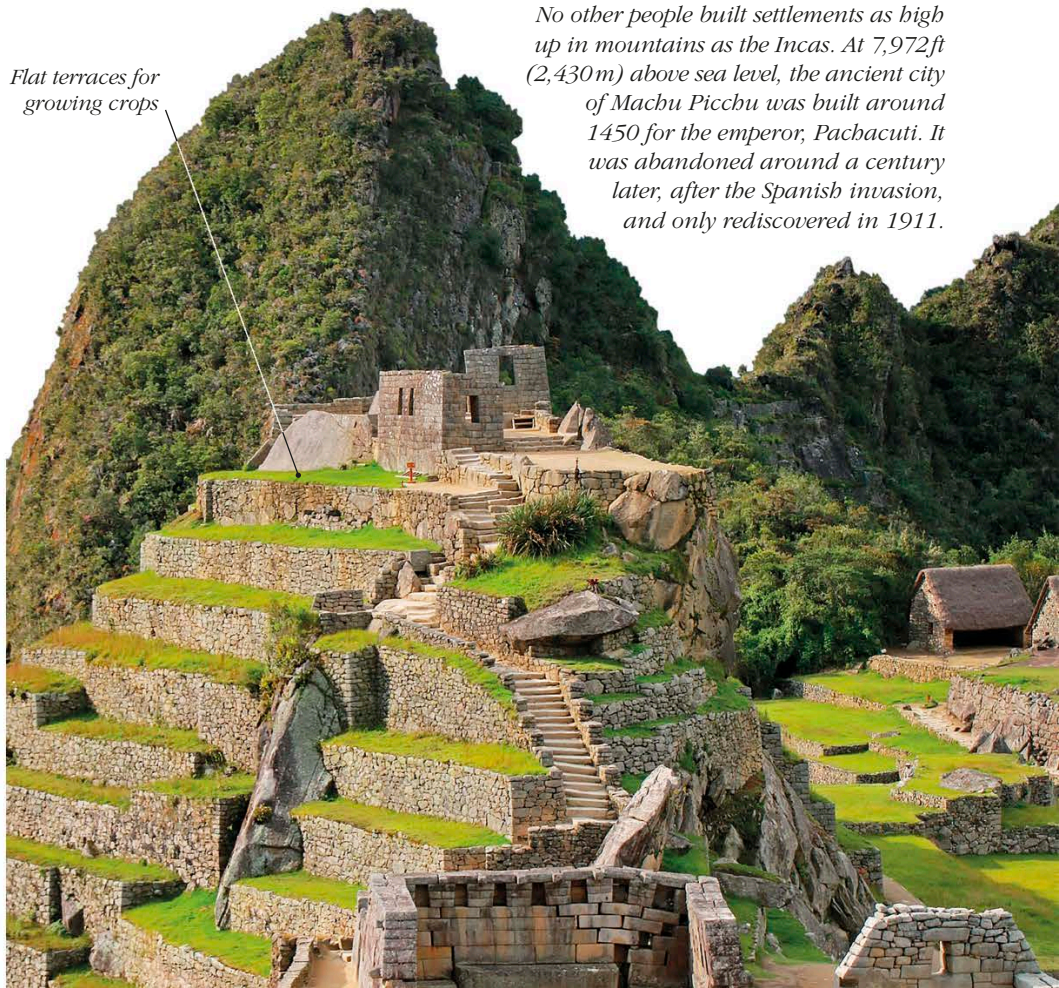
TAKE A LOOK

Despite the Spanish conquest, many features of Inca daily life continue today. Many Indigenous communities still weave colorful textiles from alpaca and llama wool using a traditional loom, as they have for thousands of years.



PERUVIAN
WEAVER

Flat terraces for growing crops



MACHU PICCHU ▼

No other people built settlements as high up in mountains as the Incas. At 7,972ft (2,430m) above sea level, the ancient city of Machu Picchu was built around 1450 for the emperor, Pachacuti. It was abandoned around a century later, after the Spanish invasion, and only rediscovered in 1911.